

A La Carte

By AL CARTWRIGHT

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THIS IS THE PHILLIES' SECOND EXTENDED ROAD trip, as they say on the radio, so Andy Cohen hardly figures to get lost.

Still, you never know. Thirty years is an awfully long say time, and it might take more than twice around the track are for the man to regain his bearings.

It's been that long between big-league berths for the jolly little 55-year-old who is the Phils' first-base coach. And that might be a record for interims.

The last time Cohen had on a major-league suit, it had New York Giants across the front of it. That was in 1929, when he hit .284 in his third season but still was dealt off to Newark and the minors in exchange for Hub Pruett, the pitcher, when the Giants decided Hughie Critz was their man for second base.

Three decades later, here comes Cohen again, and his gay wardrobe and his cigar-holder and his wonderful disposition. Have times changed, you ask him? Well, he replies, Art Fletcher isn't managing the Phillies any more, and Joe McCarthy is gone from the Cubs, and there ain't no more Polo Grounds or Boston or Ebbets Field.

"The ball players, Andy," the interviewer broke in. "and the general atmosphere, maybe. Or, what's the biggest difference you notice in the big-league game, since you last had a look at it?"

Coach Cohen had several answers. He doesn't see much difference in the calibre of play—"it's no better, no worse, still big league." But he is meeting a new type of major-leaguer, one who is business-minded, security-bent. And he watches them go into action with much better equipment than in his palmy days as John McGraw's Jewish discovery.

That's a Glove?

THE BALTIMORE-BORN COHEN, WHO PLAYED IN THE same Alabama backfield with Johnny Mack Brown, reached into his locker and emerged with something resembling a baseball glove. Closer inspection disclosed that it was a baseball glove, but you could be excused for mistaking it for a Bowery wheatscake. It was that flat, that stiff.

"This was my glove with the Giants," Cohen said, with dignity. "I showed it to the boys the other day and they




Andy Cohen
... a 30-year zip

almost died laughing. One of them claimed this must have been the reason we had 400 hitters then, if this was what the fielders wore. Now they've got those scoops with the long fingers and the big pockets, and I've got to admit there is no comparison.

"Take those batting helmets. Put one of 'em on in my day, and you'd be laughed out of the league. And they wear shorts under the uniform, in place of tying on the old sliding pads. Equipment has improved tremendously—I'd say that's the big difference. Nowadays, glasses are taken in Ti, stride—even catchers wear 'em. When I played, only three players in the league wore glasses. The Pirates had two of them, both pitchers—Lee Meadows, Carmen Hill. George Toporcer, the infielder, wore 'em in the other league. And an infielder then wouldn't think of wearing sunglasses. We'd put soot under our eyes."

Cohen recalls that his fellow big-league players were more colorful, with a bigger share of screwballs—"they'd play for the fun of it, if they had too—but says you can't beat today's baseball economics. His best payday, by the way, was \$10,500.

"I know guys who were playing for \$2,500 a season. And Johnny Mostil told me he was getting only \$100 a month as the regular center fielder for the White Sox. Now you have the minimum salary, the pension, the bonus."

Cohen Batting for Frisch

COHEN WAS IN HIS SECOND SEASON AS A PRO WHEN the Giants brought him up from Waco in 1928 to help out in the infield because Travis Jackson was sore-legged. He made his debut in the Phillies' Baker Bowl, angling as a pinch-hitter for Frankie Frisch, of all immortals for whom to pinch-hit. "Frisch hurt his heel, and we had a nine-run lead."

The rookie Cohen was hardly greeted with open arms. "Not like today," Andy said, "when a rookie has just as much right to the diamond as the veterans and has specialized coaching. In the '20s, an older guy would see a rookie come in and immediately start thinking 'This punk ain't out to get my job.' The rookie was self-conscious about his appearance, got pushed around. Sometimes the manager would have to take him by the hand to get him into batting practice."

"I must say, though, that Frisch was nice to me. He was a high-type gent, and I was just another kid to him. I even used to feel proud when he'd bum my passes for the day."

Cohen sees little physical change in the ball players, except that fewer little fellows are pitching.

"The scouts are ordered to bring in big pitchers," he commented. "In my time, I saw more pitchers under 6 feet 6—Ray Pierce, Art Herring, Lloyd Davies, others. That was P-I-E-R-C-E. He—ahem—was pitching for the Phillies the day I got that single."

Andy Cohen goes around the league and he takes it all in just like Tony Curry or Ken Walters or Jim Coker. He's been there before, but the St. Louis and Chicago parks never looked like this. And whatever happened to the Auditorium in Chicago and the Sinton in Cincinnati, two hotels McGraw patronized because he knew the owners? Andy's old Giants are in Frisco, the Dodgers in L. A., the Braves in Milwaukee. No more Baker Bowl.

The dugouts are full of strangers, too. Of his Giant playmates, only Freddie Fitzsimmons is still putting on the knickers, and he's coaching in the other league with the A's. That's the Kansas City A's, Andy. There have been some changes over there, too.